Chapter 3 — Control Flow

By default a program runs statements top to bottom, once each. **Control flow** statements change that: they *choose* between paths (`if`, `switch`), *repeat* work (`for`, `while`, `do`), and *jump* (`break`, `continue`, `return`). Modern Java (16–21) also added **pattern matching**, which lets one construct both test the shape of a value and pull data out of it — turning long `if`/cast chains into short, compiler-checked `switch` expressions.

What you'll learn

#	Topic	You will be able to…
3.1	`if` / `else`	write decision chains and avoid the dangling-else trap
3.2	The classic `switch` statement	use colon labels, `break`, fall-through and `default`
3.3	Arrow labels and `switch` expressions (Java 14)	return a value from a `switch`, use `yield`, rely on exhaustiveness
3.4	Choosing between `if`, ternary and `switch`	pick the clearest construct
3.5	Pattern matching for `instanceof` (Java 16)	test and bind in one step; understand flow scoping
3.6	Pattern matching for `switch` (Java 21)	type patterns, guards, `case null`, dominance, sealed exhaustiveness
3.7	Record patterns (Java 21) and unnamed patterns (Java 22)	deconstruct records, nest patterns, use `_`
3.8	Loops: `while`, `do-while`, `for`, enhanced `for`	choose and write the right loop
3.9	`break`, `continue` and labels	exit and skip iterations, including nested loops
3.10	Loop pitfalls	spot off-by-one, concurrent modification and other silent bugs

Code: `code/`, compiled with `javac --release 25`, output pasted from real runs. Records and sealed interfaces appear here only as data for patterns; they are taught properly in Chapter 6. For exam-level traps (which types a `switch` accepts, pattern-variable scope puzzles, loop-label trickery, unreachable code), see the OCP repo's Chapter 3 — Making Decisions.

3.1 `if`, `else if`, `else`

What it is

`if (condition) statement` runs the statement only when the **boolean** condition is `true`; an optional `else` runs otherwise. Chaining `else if` tests several conditions in order and runs the **first** branch whose condition holds.

Analogy: a receptionist checking a list top to bottom — the first rule that matches decides where you go.

How it works

1. Evaluate the condition — it must have type `boolean` (or `Boolean`). Unlike C or JavaScript, `if (x)` with an `int x` is a compile error: *incompatible types: int cannot be converted to boolean*.
2. If `true`, run the `if` body and skip every `else`.
3. Otherwise try the next `else if`; if none match, run the final `else` (if present).

`code/IfElse.java`:

```java
static String grade(int score) {
    if (score < 0 || score > 100) {
        return "invalid";
    } else if (score >= 90) {
        return "A";
    } else if (score >= 80) {
        return "B";
    } else if (score >= 70) {
        return "C";
    } else {
        return "F";
    }
}

// Dangling else: the else belongs to the NEAREST if, whatever the indentation says.
int x = 5, y = -1;
if (x > 0)
    if (y > 0)
        System.out.println("both positive");
else
    System.out.println("printed! this else pairs with 'if (y > 0)'");
```

Output:

```
95 -> A
85 -> B
72 -> C
40 -> F
101 -> invalid
Beach day
printed! this else pairs with 'if (y > 0)'
minor
```

Order matters: because the chain stops at the first match, test the narrow or invalid cases first (`score >= 90` before `score >= 80`).

Common mistakes

- **Dangling else** (above): Java ignores indentation; an `else` attaches to the closest unmatched `if`. Always use braces for nested `if`s.
- Omitting braces, then adding a second line that you think is inside the `if`:

  ```java
  if (loggedIn)
      showDashboard();
      audit();          // ALWAYS runs — only the first statement is controlled by the if
  ```

- `if (flag = true)` — assignment, not comparison; it compiles for `boolean` and is always true. Write `if (flag)`.
- Comparing strings with `==` in a condition (Chapter 2).
- Deep nesting. Prefer **guard clauses** — return early for invalid input so the main logic stays flat.

Self-check

1. Does `if (count)` compile for `int count`? → No; conditions must be boolean.
2. In an `if` / `else if` chain, can two branches run? → No, only the first matching one.
3. How do you prevent the dangling-else problem? → Braces on every nested `if`.

3.2 The classic `switch` statement

What it is

A `switch` compares one value (the **selector**) against constant **case labels** and jumps to the matching one. It replaces a long `if (x == 1) … else if (x == 2) …` chain when you are testing one variable for equality against constants.

How it works (colon form, the original since Java 1.0)

1. Evaluate the selector once.
2. Jump to the `case` whose constant equals it, or to `default` if none does (if there is no `default`, nothing runs).
3. Execute statements from there **downwards** until a `break` (or `return` / `throw`) or the end of the `switch`. Running into the next case's statements is called **fall-through**.

`code/SwitchStatement.java`:

```
int month = 4;
int days;
switch (month) {
    case 2:
        days = 28;
        break;
    case 4: case 6: case 9: case 11:        // several labels share one body
        days = 30;
        break;
    default:
        days = 31;
}

int level = 2;
switch (level) {
    case 1:
        System.out.println("  unlock level 1 perks");
    case 2:
        System.out.println("  unlock level 2 perks");
    case 3:
        System.out.println("  unlock level 3 perks");   // runs too: no break above
        break;
    case 4:
        System.out.println("  not reached");
}
```

Output:

```
month 4 has 30 days
stopping
Fall-through without break (level 2):
  unlock level 2 perks
  unlock level 3 perks
SAT is weekend
b is a consonant
```

What can you switch on?

Selector type	Since	Case labels
`char`, `byte`, `short`, `int` and their wrappers	Java 1.0 / 5	compile-time constants that fit the type (`'a'`, `42`, `final` constants)
`enum`	Java 5	constant names (`case SAT`); qualified names (`case Day.SAT`) also allowed since Java 21
`String`	Java 7	string literals; compared with `equals` (case-sensitive)
Any reference type with patterns	Java 21	type/record patterns, `null` (3.6)
`long`, `float`, `double`, `boolean`	not allowed	(primitive patterns are only a *preview* – JEP 507 in Java 25, still preview in 27)

Labels must be unique, and a `String`/boxed selector that is `null` throws `NullPointerException` unless there is a `case null` (Java 21).

When fall-through is useful – and when not

Intentional fall-through (shared code for several labels, or cumulative steps like the perks example) is rare. Forgetting a `break` is a far more common bug, which is why the arrow form below exists. If you do fall through on purpose, comment it (`// fall through`).

In the interview

Q: What is fall-through in a `switch`? In colon-style `switch`, execution continues from the matched label into the following labels' statements until a `break`. It is a frequent source of bugs; arrow labels (`case X ->`) never fall through.

- *Can you switch on a `String`? How does it compare?* Yes (Java 7); with `equals`, after a `hashCode` jump.
- *What happens with a `null` selector?* `NullPointerException`, unless a `case null` label is present (Java 21+).

3.3 Arrow labels and `switch` expressions (Java 14)

What it is

Java 14 (JEP 361) finalised two related improvements:

- **Arrow labels** `case A, B -> …` – several constants per label, the right side is a single expression, block `{ }` or `throw`, and there is **no fall-through**. They can be used in `switch` *statements* too.
- `switch` **expressions** – a `switch` that **produces a value**, so you can write `int x = switch (…) { … };` or `return switch (…) { … };`.

Why it matters

Classic `switch` used to compute a value needs a pre-declared variable, an assignment in every case, a `break` in every case and a `default` to keep the compiler happy about definite assignment. Each of those is a chance for a bug. The expression form removes all of them, and the compiler checks that **every possible value is handled** (*exhaustiveness*).

How it works

1. The selector is evaluated; the matching label is chosen.
2. For `case … -> expression;` the expression's value becomes the switch's value.
3. For `case … -> { … }` the block must end by `yield value;` (or throw). `yield` means "this is the result of the switch" – it is not `return`, which would leave the whole method.
4. The switch expression must be **exhaustive**: for `int`/`String` selectors that means a `default`; for an `enum` it is enough to list every constant; for sealed types, every permitted subtype (3.6).

`code/SwitchExpression.java`:

```
enum Size { S, M, L, XL }

static int priceCents(Size size) {
    return switch (size) {                      // no default needed: all enum constants covered
        case S -> 250;
        case M -> 300;
        case L, XL -> 350;
    };
}

static String describe(int code) {
    return switch (code) {
        case 200, 201, 204 -> "success";
        case 301, 302 -> "redirect";
        case 404 -> "not found";
        default -> {
            String family = code >= 500 ? "server error" : "other";
            yield family + " (" + code + ")";    // yield returns a value from a block
        }
    };
}

// yield also works with old-style colon labels inside a switch expression
String kind = switch (letters % 2) {
    case 0:
        yield "even";
    default:
        yield "odd";
};
```

Output:

```
S=250 M=300 L=350 XL=350
200 -> success
302 -> redirect
404 -> not found
503 -> server error (503)
418 -> other (418)
WEDNESDAY has 9 letters
9 is odd
```

If one enum constant is missing, compilation fails:

```
B.java:4: error: the switch expression does not cover all possible input values
        return switch (s) {
               ^
```

That is the real benefit: add `XXL` to `Size` later and the compiler points to every `switch` that must handle it. (If an enum gains a constant and a `switch` compiled against the old version meets it at run time, the JVM throws `MatchException`.)

Statement vs expression, colon vs arrow

	Colon labels `case X:`	Arrow labels `case X ->`
Statement	Classic; fall-through; `break` needed	No fall-through; one expression/block/throw per label
Expression	Allowed; must `yield` a value; fall-through possible	The usual modern form
Exhaustive?	Statement: only if it uses patterns or `null` (Java 21 rule). Expression: **always**	same

You cannot mix colon and arrow labels in one `switch`.

Common mistakes

- Forgetting the semicolon after the closing brace of a switch *expression* used in an assignment (`};`).
- Using `return` inside a switch-expression block to produce the value (compile error) — use `yield`.
- Adding `default` to an enum switch expression "just in case": it silences the exhaustiveness check that would have caught a newly added constant. Leave it out when you cover all constants.

Self-check

1. What does `yield` do? → Supplies the value of a switch expression from a block.
2. Do arrow cases fall through? → Never.
3. Why may an enum switch expression omit `default`? → Listing all constants makes it exhaustive; the compiler verifies it.

3.4 Choosing between `if`, ternary and `switch`

Situation	Best choice	Why
One condition, two actions	`if` / `else`	Clearest
One condition, pick one of two **values**	ternary `c ? a : b`	An expression; short
Ranges or unrelated conditions (`age < 13`, `isVip && total > 100`)	`if` / `else if` chain (or guarded patterns)	`switch` labels are constants/patterns, not ranges
One variable compared to many constants	`switch` with arrow labels	Readable, no fall-through
Compute a value from many cases	`switch` expression	Exhaustive, no temporary variable
Branch on the **type/shape** of an object	pattern `switch` (Java 21)	Replaces `instanceof` chains; compiler-checked for sealed types
Behaviour that varies per subtype and grows over time	**Polymorphism** (a method on each class)	The OOP alternative; see Chapter 6 and the LLD handbook

The last two rows are a genuine design choice. A pattern `switch` over a *sealed* hierarchy keeps an operation in one place and makes adding an **operation** easy; virtual methods keep each type's code together and make adding a **type** easy. This is known as the *expression problem*.

3.5 Pattern matching for `instanceof` (Java 16)

What it is

A **pattern** combines a *test* ("is this a `String`?") with *binding* ("…and if so, call it `s`"). `o instanceof String s` is a **type pattern** (JEP 394, final in Java 16): when the test succeeds, the **pattern variable** `s` is already

cast and ready to use.

The problem it solves

The old idiom repeats the type three times and allows mistakes (casting to the wrong type, forgetting the check):

```
if (o instanceof String) {
    String s = (String) o;
    ...
}
```

How it works — flow scoping

A pattern variable is in scope **only where the compiler can prove the match succeeded**:

1. Inside the `if` body when the condition is `o instanceof T t`.
2. On the right-hand side of `&&` (`o instanceof String s && !s.isEmpty()`), because `&&` only evaluates its right side when the left is true.
3. **After** the `if` when the `if` tests the *negation* and exits (`if (!(o instanceof String s)) return 0; … s.length()`).
4. **Not** with `||` — `o instanceof String s || s.isEmpty()` fails with *cannot find symbol*, because the right side runs precisely when the match failed.

`code/InstanceofPattern.java`:

```
static String newStyle(Object o) {
    if (o instanceof String s && !s.isEmpty()) {     // s is in scope on the right of &&
        return "String of length " + s.length();
    }
    if (o instanceof Integer i) return "Integer, doubled " + (i * 2);
    return "something else: " + o;
}

static int lengthOrZero(Object o) {
    if (!(o instanceof String s)) {
        return 0;                                    // leave early when it is NOT a String
    }
    return s.length();                               // flow scoping: s is definitely a String here
}

record Money(long cents, String currency) {
    @Override public boolean equals(Object other) {  // a classic use: equals()
        return other instanceof Money m && cents == m.cents && currency.equals(m.currency);
    }
}
```

Output:

```
String of length 5
String of length 5 | Integer, doubled 42 | something else:  | something else: null
lengthOrZero: 3, 0
true
```

Notes:

- `null instanceof X` is always `false`, so a pattern never binds `null`.
- The pattern variable is an ordinary local; it is not `final` unless you declare it `final String s`.
- An *unconditional* pattern — testing a `String` variable with `instanceof String s`, which can only fail for `null` — was a compile error in Java 16–20 and is allowed since Java 21.

Real-world examples

`equals(Object)` implementations (as above), handling heterogeneous JSON nodes (`if (node instanceof ObjectNode obj)`), and exception handling code that inspects causes (`if (e.getCause() instanceof SQLException sql)`).

3.6 Pattern matching for `switch` (Java 21)

What it is

Java 21 (JEP 441) lets `case` labels contain **patterns**, not just constants. A single `switch` can test the type of any object, bind variables, apply extra conditions and handle `null`.

How it works

1. **Type pattern** – `case Integer i ->` matches when the selector is an `Integer` and binds `i`.
2. **Guard** – `case Integer i when i < 0 ->` adds a boolean condition (`when` is a contextual keyword). The case only matches if the pattern matches **and** the guard is true.
3. **`case null`** – without it, a `null` selector throws `NullPointerException` (backward compatible with old `switch`). `case null, default ->` combines both.
4. **Order and dominance** – cases are tried top to bottom. A label is a compile error if an earlier label already matches everything it would (e.g. `CharSequence cs` before `String s`), so write **specific cases before general ones**, and guarded cases before the unguarded case of the same type.
5. **Exhaustiveness** – a pattern `switch` (expression *or* statement) must cover every possible value: add `default`, or cover all permitted subtypes of a **sealed** type.

`code/SwitchPatterns.java`:

```
sealed interface Shape permits Circle, Square, Rectangle {}
record Circle(double radius) implements Shape {}
record Square(double side) implements Shape {}
record Rectangle(double width, double height) implements Shape {}

static double area(Shape shape) {
    return switch (shape) {                          // exhaustive: every permitted subtype covered
        case Circle c -> Math.PI * c.radius() * c.radius();
        case Square s -> s.side() * s.side();
        case Rectangle r -> r.width() * r.height();
    };
}

static String classify(Object o) {
    return switch (o) {
        case null -> "null!";                        // without this case, switch throws NPE
        case Integer i when i < 0 -> "negative int " + i;   // guard
        case Integer i -> "int " + i;
        case String s when s.isBlank() -> "blank string";
        case String s -> "string of " + s.length();
        case int[] arr -> "int array of " + arr.length;
        case Shape sh -> "shape with area " + String.format("%.2f", area(sh));
        default -> "other: " + o.getClass().getSimpleName();
    };
}
```

Output:

```
negative int -7
int 42
blank string
string of 5
int array of 3
shape with area 3.14
shape with area 6.00
other: Double
null!
```

A **sealed** interface (Java 17) lists all its implementations with `permits`, so the compiler knows `area`'s three cases are complete — no `default`. Add a `Triangle` to `permits` and every such `switch` fails to compile until it handles triangles.

Real compiler errors you will meet:

```
A.java:12: error: this case label is dominated by a preceding case label
            case String s -> "string";
                 ^
```

```
B.java:10: error: the switch statement does not cover all possible input values
        switch (o) {
        ^
```

Trade-offs

Approach	Pros	Cons
`if` / `instanceof` chain	Works on any Java version ≥ 16	Easy to forget a type; order-sensitive; verbose
Pattern `switch` + sealed types	Exhaustive, compact, a value-producing expression	Every `switch` must change when a subtype is added (which is the point)
Polymorphic method	Adding a type touches one place	Adding an operation touches every class

When not to use it

For a genuinely open hierarchy (plug-ins, user-defined subclasses) you cannot list the cases; a `default` branch or polymorphism fits better. And for equality against constants, the simple constant `switch` is still clearer.

In the interview

Q: What does pattern matching for `switch` give you over `instanceof` chains? Type test, cast and binding in one label; guards with `when`; explicit `null` handling; and compile-time exhaustiveness and dominance checks — especially powerful with sealed hierarchies and records, where adding a subtype makes the compiler flag every switch that must be updated.

- *What is a guard?* A `when` boolean condition attached to a pattern label.
- *Why does label order matter?* The first matching label wins, and a label dominated by an earlier one is a compile error.
- *Does a pattern switch accept `null`?* Only with a `case null`; otherwise it throws `NullPointerException`.

Self-check

1. Where must `case String s when s.isEmpty()` go relative to `case String s`? → Before it.
2. Why does `switch (shape)` above need no `default`? → `Shape` is sealed; all permitted subtypes are covered.
3. Is a pattern `switch` *statement* required to be exhaustive? → Yes (Java 21 rule for switches that use patterns or `null`).

3.7 Record patterns (Java 21) and unnamed patterns (Java 22)

What it is

A **record** is a compact class whose purpose is to carry data (Java 16; Chapter 6): `record Point(int x, int y) {}` gets a constructor, accessors `x()` / `y()`, `equals`, `hashCode` and `toString` automatically. A **record pattern** (JEP 440, Java 21) matches a record **and deconstructs it** into its components in one step: `o instanceof Point(int x, int y)`.

The **unnamed pattern** `_` (JEP 456, Java 22) matches anything and binds nothing — use it for components you do not care about. `_` can also name unused variables (`catch (Exception _)`, `for (var _ : list)`, lambda parameters `(_, v) -> v`).

How it works

1. The value is tested against the record type (`null` never matches).
2. Each component is extracted through its accessor and matched against the nested pattern: a type (`int x`), `var x` (infer the type), another record pattern (nesting), or `_`.
3. Record patterns can be used in `instanceof` and in `switch`, with guards.

`code/RecordPatterns.java` — a tiny expression evaluator, a textbook use of sealed records plus patterns:

```
record Point(int x, int y) {}
sealed interface Expr permits Num, Add, Mul, Neg {}
record Num(int value) implements Expr {}
record Add(Expr left, Expr right) implements Expr {}
record Mul(Expr left, Expr right) implements Expr {}
record Neg(Expr operand) implements Expr {}

static int eval(Expr e) {
    return switch (e) {
        case Num(int v) -> v;
        case Add(Expr l, Expr r) -> eval(l) + eval(r);
        case Mul(Num(var v), _) when v == 0 -> 0;          // nested pattern + unnamed _ + guard
        case Mul(Expr l, Expr r) -> eval(l) * eval(r);
        case Neg(var inner) -> -eval(inner);
    };
}

Object o = new Point(3, 4);
if (o instanceof Point(int x, int y)) {             // deconstruct in one step
    System.out.println("x=" + x + " y=" + y + " distance=" + Math.sqrt(x * x + y * y));
}
if (o instanceof Point(var x, _)) System.out.println("only care about x: " + x);
```

Output:

```
x=3 y=4 distance=5.0
only care about x: 3
(2 + 3 * -4) = -10
0 * (1 + 2) = 0
```

The `Mul(Num(var v), _) when v == 0` case short-circuits multiplication by zero without evaluating the right side — a nested pattern reads like the data's shape. This style (sealed interface + records + exhaustive pattern switch) is how modern Java models **algebraic data types**: ASTs in compilers, JSON values, commands/events, and results such as `Success | Failure`.

Still in preview (don't rely on it yet)

Primitive types in patterns, `instanceof` and `switch` — e.g. `switch` on a `long` or `case int i` matching a `double` that fits — is a preview feature (JEP 507 in Java 25; still preview in 26 and 27). Without `--enable-preview`, switching on a `long` fails: *primitive patterns are a preview feature and are disabled by default.*

Self-check

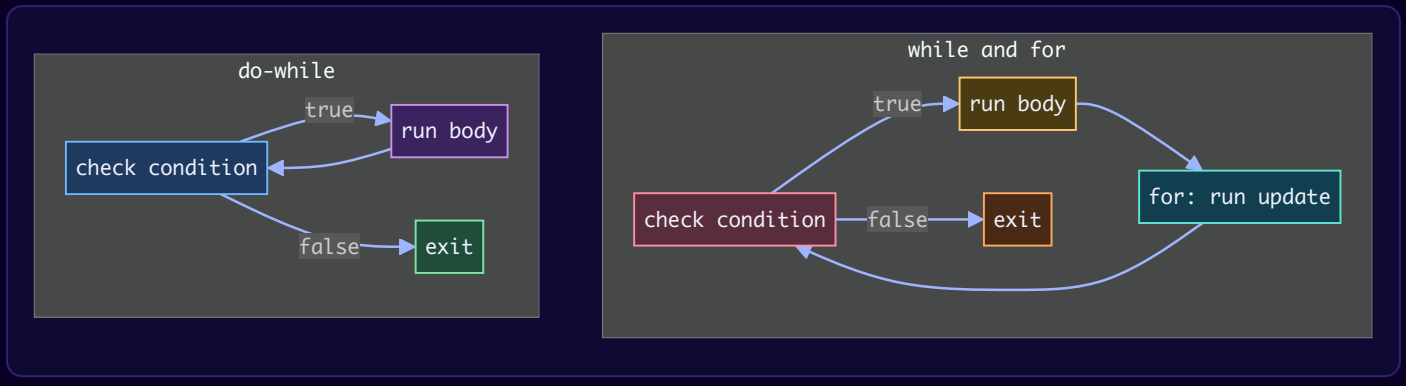
1. What does `case Add(var l, var r)` bind? → The two components of an `Add` record, with inferred types.
2. What does `_` mean in `Point(var x, _)`? → Match any `y` and ignore it (Java 22).
3. Does `null instanceof Point(int x, int y)` match? → No.

3.8 Loops

What it is

A **loop** repeats a statement (the *body*) while a condition holds, or once per element of a collection. Each run of the body is an **iteration**.

Loop	Checks condition	Runs at least once?	Typical use
`while (cond) body`	before each iteration	no	unknown number of repetitions: reading until end of input, waiting for a state
`do body while (cond);`	after each iteration	yes	menus, retry-until-success, input validation
`for (init; cond; update) body`	before each iteration	no	counting, index-based access
`for (T x : iterable) body` (enhanced for, Java 5)	–	no	visit every element of an array or `Iterable`



`code/Loops.java` :

```java
int n = 9075, digitSum = 0;
while (n > 0) {                      // condition checked BEFORE each iteration
    digitSum += n % 10;
    n /= 10;
}

int attempts = 0;
int[] fakeRolls = {2, 5, 6, 3};
int roll;
do {                                 // body runs at least once; condition checked AFTER
    roll = fakeRolls[attempts++];
    System.out.print("rolled " + roll + "; ");
} while (roll != 6);

long factorial = 1;
for (int i = 1; i <= 10; i++) {      // init; condition; update
    factorial *= i;
}

for (int i = 0, j = 10; i < j; i += 3, j -= 3) {   // several variables of one type
    System.out.print("(" + i + "," + j + ") ");
}
for (int i = 10; i > 0; i /= 2) System.out.print(i + " ");   // any update expression

int[] temps = {21, 25, 19, 30};
int max = Integer.MIN_VALUE;
for (int t : temps) max = Math.max(max, t);   // enhanced for over an array

Map<String, Integer> stock = new TreeMap<>(Map.of("apple", 3, "pear", 0, "fig", 7));
for (Map.Entry<String, Integer> e : stock.entrySet()) {
    System.out.print(e.getKey() + ":" + e.getValue() + " ");
}
```

Output:

```
digit sum of 9075 = 21
rolled 2; rolled 5; rolled 6; got a 6 after 3 attempts
10! = 3628800
(0,10) (3,7)
10 5 2 1
max temp = 30
ADA GRACE LINUS
apple:3 fig:7 pear:0
1 2 Fizz 4 Buzz Fizz 7 8 Fizz Buzz 11 Fizz 13 14 FizzBuzz
```

The `for` loop in detail

1. **Initialisation** runs once. It may declare several variables *of the same type* (`int i = 0, j = 10`); they are scoped to the loop.
2. **Condition** is checked before every iteration; if omitted, it is `true` (`for (;;)` is an infinite loop).
3. **Body** runs.
4. **Update** runs after each body (several expressions separated by commas are allowed), then back to step 2.

The enhanced `for` in detail

`for (T x : source)` works for **arrays** and anything that implements `Iterable` (all collections). The compiler turns it into an index loop for arrays and an `Iterator` loop for collections. Use it whenever you need each element and not its index. Its limits:

- No index (use a classic `for`, or `IntStream.range` – Chapter 12).
- The loop variable is a **copy** for primitives: assigning to it does not change the array.
- You must not add/remove elements of the collection being iterated (3.10).
- Iterating a `Map` directly is impossible – iterate `entrySet()`, `keySet()` or `values()`.

Loops vs streams

Many loops that filter, transform and aggregate can be written as streams (Chapter 12): `Arrays.stream(temps).max()`. Loops remain the right tool when you need early exits with complex state, index arithmetic, or maximum performance on primitive arrays; streams read better for pipelines of transformations.

In the interview

Q: `while` vs `do-while`? `while` tests before the first iteration and may run zero times; `do-while` tests after, so it runs at least once — useful for "prompt until valid" loops.

- *When do you prefer the enhanced `for`?* Whenever you only need the elements, not indexes, and are not modifying the collection's structure.
- *How is the enhanced `for` compiled for a `List`?* Into an `Iterator` loop (`hasNext` / `next`).

Self-check

1. How many times does `for (int i = 0; i < 10; i += 3)` run? → 4 (0, 3, 6, 9).
2. Can `for (int i = 0, long j = 0; …)` compile? → No; one declaration type only.
3. Which loop suits "ask for a password until it is valid"? → `do-while`.

3.9 `break`, `continue` and labels

What it is

- `break` exits the innermost loop (or `switch`) immediately.
- `continue` skips the rest of the current iteration and proceeds with the next one (in a `for`, the update still runs).
- A **label** (`name:` before a loop) lets `break name;` or `continue name;` target an **outer** loop. `return` exits the whole method, which is often the cleanest way out of nested loops.

`code/Branching.java`:

```java
for (int v : data) {
    if (v < 0) {
        System.out.println("found a negative, stopping");
        break;                                  // leave the loop entirely
    }
    System.out.println("processing " + v);
}

for (int i = 1; i <= 10; i++) {
    if (i % 3 != 0) continue;                   // skip the rest of this iteration
    System.out.print(i + " ");
}

search:                                         // a label names the outer loop
for (int r = 0; r < grid.length; r++) {
    for (int c = 0; c < grid[r].length; c++) {
        if (grid[r][c] == target) {
            foundRow = r;
            foundCol = c;
            break search;                       // exits BOTH loops
        }
    }
}

outer:
for (int i = 1; i <= 3; i++) {
    for (int j = 1; j <= 3; j++) {
        if (j == i) continue outer;             // jump to the next i
        System.out.print(i + "" + j + " ");
    }
}

while (true) {                                   // loop-and-a-half: exit in the middle
    String line = lines[idx++];
    if (line.isEmpty()) break;
    System.out.print(line + " ");
}
```

Output:

```
processing 4
processing 8
found a negative, stopping
3 6 9 <- multiples of 3
42 found at (1,1)
21 31 32 <- pairs with j < i
alpha beta <- read until blank line
```

Trade-offs

Technique	Good for	Watch out
`break` / `continue`	Early exit, skipping invalid items	Many of them in one loop hide the control flow
Labelled `break`	Leaving nested loops (grid search)	Rarely needed; often clearer to extract a method and `return`
`while (true)` + `break`	"Loop-and-a-half": read, test, process	Make sure every path eventually breaks
`return`	Leaving everything once the answer is found	–

Java has no `goto` (the word is reserved but unused); labels only work with `break` / `continue` on enclosing statements. Code directly after an unconditional `break` / `continue` / `return` in the same block is **unreachable** and a compile error.

Self-check

1. In a `for` loop, does `continue` skip the update expression? → No, the update still runs.
2. How do you leave two nested loops at once? → A labelled `break`, or put the loops in a method and `return`.
3. What does `break` inside a `switch` inside a loop exit? → Only the `switch`.

3.10 Loop pitfalls

`code/LoopPitfalls.java` – each compiles fine:

```
int[] a = {10, 20, 30};
for (int i = 0; i <= a.length; i++) System.out.print(a[i] + " ");   // off-by-one: <= should be <

List<Integer> nums = new ArrayList<>(List.of(1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6));
for (Integer x : nums) if (x % 2 == 0) nums.remove(x);   // structural change during for-each

for (Iterator<Integer> it = nums.iterator(); it.hasNext(); ) {
    if (it.next() % 2 == 0) it.remove();                      // fix 1: Iterator.remove
}
more.removeIf(x -> x % 2 == 0);                               // fix 2: removeIf (Java 8)

for (double d = 0.0; d != 1.0 && count < 20; d += 0.1) count++; // d never equals 1.0 exactly

for (int v : values) v *= 10;                  // changes the copy, not the array

for (int i = 0; i < 5; i++); { total++; }      // stray ';' = empty loop body
```

Output:

```
10 20 30
off-by-one -> Index 3 out of bounds for length 3
remove in for-each -> ConcurrentModificationException
after Iterator.remove: [1, 3, 5]
after removeIf: [1, 3, 5]
double counter ran 20 times (guard stopped it)
values after 'v *= 10' in for-each: [1, 2, 3]
stray semicolon: block ran 1 time(s)
```

Pitfall	Why it happens	Fix
Off-by-one (`<=` with `length`)	Indexes run 0 … length−1	`i < a.length`; prefer enhanced `for`
`ConcurrentModificationException`	Collections like `ArrayList` are *fail-fast*: their iterator detects structural changes made behind its back (Chapter 10). Detection is best-effort — removing the second-to-last element can even end the loop silently without the exception, leaving a wrong result.	`Iterator.remove()`, `removeIf`, or build a new list
Floating-point loop counter	0.1 is inexact, so `d` never equals 1.0 (Chapter 2)	Loop over an `int` and compute `i * 0.1`
Assigning the for-each variable	It is a copy of the element	Index loop: `values[i] *= 10`
Stray semicolon after `for (…)` / `while (…)`	`;` is an empty statement that becomes the body	Always use braces; IDEs warn
Infinite loop	Condition never becomes false (forgot `i++`, or `while (x != 10)` when `x` jumps from 9 to 11)	Update the loop variable; prefer `<` / `>` over `!=`
Integer overflow of the counter	`for (int i = 0; i <= Integer.MAX_VALUE; i++)` never ends — `i` wraps negative	Use `<` or a `long`
Expensive condition	`for (int i = 0; i < list.size(); i++)` on a `LinkedList` with `get(i)` is $O(n^2)$	Enhanced `for` /iterator

Self-check

1. Why can removing inside a for-each fail? → The fail-fast iterator sees the list changed structurally and throws `ConcurrentModificationException`.
2. Two safe ways to remove matching elements while iterating? → `Iterator.remove()` or `Collection.removeIf`.
3. What does `for (int i = 0; i < 3; i++);` do? → Loops three times over an empty statement.

Chapter TL;DR

- `if` / `else if` / `else`: first true branch wins; conditions must be `boolean`; use braces to avoid the dangling-else and "second statement" traps; prefer guard clauses to deep nesting.
- Classic `switch` (colon labels) falls through until `break`; works on `int`-like types, wrappers, `enum`, `String` — never `long` / `float` / `double` / `boolean` (primitive patterns are still preview).
- Arrow labels (Java 14) never fall through; **switch expressions** return a value, use `yield` inside blocks, and must be exhaustive (enum constants listed or `default`).
- `instanceof` patterns (Java 16) test + cast + bind; the variable is in scope only where the match is certain (`&&`, negated early-exit), not with `||`.
- Pattern `switch` (Java 21): type patterns, `when` guards, `case null`, dominance (specific before general) and exhaustiveness — with sealed types no `default` is needed and adding a subtype breaks every incomplete switch at compile time.
- Record patterns (Java 21) deconstruct records, nest, and use `var`; `_` (Java 22) ignores parts. Sealed interface + records + pattern switch = algebraic data types in Java.
- Loops: `while` (0+ times), `do-while` (1+ times), `for` (counting), enhanced `for` (every element of an array/`Iterable`, no index, no structural changes).
- `break` exits, `continue` skips, labels target outer loops; often a method + `return` is cleaner.
- Classic bugs: off-by-one, `ConcurrentModificationException`, floating counters, assigning the for-each variable, stray `;`.
- Exam-trap depth: OCP Chapter 3. Next: Chapter 4 — Methods and arrays.